travelled both to China and India. Chinese silk and porcelain found markets in Central Asia and India. When direct trade was established between India and the Roman empire in the early centuries of the Christian era, the Indian ports of Broach or Barygaza in Gujarat, Muziris in Kerala and Nagapattinam on the Coromandel coast also served as trade emporia exporting goods from China brought along the caravan routes to the Roman empire. The large hoards of Roman gold coins found from archaeological excavations in these locations testify to the scale of the trade. Some Roman gold coins have also been found in tombs in China, but much fewer in number than in India.

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In the accounts left behind by the Chinese pilgrims, India is presented as a sacred land with considerable wealth and a sophisticated culture boasting of several celebrated centres of learning. In Buddhist terms, China was described as the periphery while India was the spiritual centre. It was not only the Buddhist religion that India bestowed on China; Indian astronomy and medicine, and Sanskrit treatises on these subjects were also received with keen interest in China and were treasured and translated into Chinese. During this period, the perception of India as an independent centre of cultural and intellectual refinement, more advanced than China, began to take shape, though this was not necessarily shared by the literati schooled in Confucian classics. India was an exception to the assumed superiority of China over the ring of ‘barbarian’ races ranged around its extended land borders.

Fa Xian, Xuan Zang and Yi Jing were deeply moved by their visits to the several places of pilgrimage across India. However, from their accounts it is already apparent that Buddhism was a religion in decline in the country of its birth, and that several urban centres and monasteries were either lying in ruins or had much fewer clergy residing in the still extant ones. Buddhism appeared to be more deeply entrenched during this time in the Central Asian oasis towns. Khotan (Hetian in present-day Xinjiang) was a major centre of Buddhism, with a large number of Indian monks residing there. There were